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PRESS STATEMENT ISSUED BY THE *THINK-DO TANK GROUP* OF CIVIL SOCIETY COALITION ON SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT (CSCSD) ON EMERGING DEVELOPMENTS IN FIGHTING COVID-19 PANDEMIC IN NIGERIA.

The Think-Do Tank Group is a national arm of Civil Society Coalition on Sustainable Development (CSCSD) which is a coalition of over 2,000 member networks, NGOs, media, professional associations including the academia, youth and women groups collaborating with government to accelerate the implementation of SGDs in Nigeria (www.cscsdev.org).

Under the current difficult and challenging times, the government and some other philanthropists have initiated some moves aimed at reducing the plights of those who could be worst affected by the pandemic. CSCSD commends the Federal Government of Nigeria for initiating and leading the mobilization of relief for vulnerable citizens especially the poorest of the poor in the wake of COVID 19 in the country. However, we are concerned about ensuring equitable distribution of resources reaching the target people including the criteria to determine who the poorest of the poor are, and how the palliatives would get to them. We are also concerned about the human rights violations by the security operatives against Nigerian citizens in a bid to enforce the stay at home order in those affected states.

While commending the efforts of the Federal Government of Nigeria and other philanthropists for their benevolence, ***The Think-Do Tank Group*** calls for transparency and accountability in its coronavirus stimulus support. This will ensure that the funds provided by the tax payer and benevolent society will go into fighting the virus and support the vulnerable, so as to guide against being misappropriated by corrupt actors in our system. The public has been notified of some of the numerous supports coming from various corporate citizens and individuals both within and outside the shores of the country. There is therefore a need to ensure adequate coordination of materials and efforts so that these collective struggles would not end up being stolen by unscrupulous individuals.

Past experiences have shown that Nigeria has a history of poor management and misappropriation of public funds. This gives reason for fear that similar acts of corruption may rear its ugly head in our country again. Therefore, the following measures are proffered aimed at ensuring the adequate protection of relief materials and funds dedicated to fighting COVID 19 and its attendant problems:

Firstly, there should be an established, dedicated, well publicized and accessible data base for tracking all contributions made in cash and kind, and which should be regularly updated. This should be in public domain during and after the epidemic. This will equip Nigerians and the world at large in tracking our collective commitments to COVID-19 activities.

Secondly, ***The Think-Do Tank Group*** calls for a summarized weekly narrative reports of all expenses and distribution of materials on the intervention. This would further strengthen transparency and accountability of government, thereby enhancing the confidence of members of the public in governance. This could be linked to the data base suggested earlier.

Thirdly, citizens of Nigeria are encouraged to exercise their civic responsibility under the Nigeria Whistle Blower Act to supply information needed to expose corrupt officials and any other persons or group of persons who might be found culpable in misappropriating and mismanaging materials and funds dedicated to mitigating the effect of COVID 19 on citizens. The Government is hereby urged to take proactive actions in recouping such funds and materials and punishing all culprits irrespective of their statuses and positions.

In addition, **the *Think-Do Tank Group*** urges all security officials to be humane and respect the rights of people in their dealings with the public in the lockdown areas. There should be the establishment of a toll free line and situation room for citizens to report and upload all incidences of violation and injustice while dealing with the lock down brought about by COVID-19 while violators should be sanctioned maximally.

Since COVID-19 is already impacting on the realization of many goals of the SDGs including contributing to poverty and hunger in the land, job loss, and rights abuses, governments at all levels need to re-strategise on acceleration mechanisms to prioritize the 17 SDGs so as to focus implementation on those goals that would directly impact on the critical masses of the people.

Once again **the *Think-Do Tank Group*** applauds the efforts of the Federal Government and all partners, corporate citizens, CSOs, the academia, the media and all who have contributed or have intentions to contribute towards fighting the pandemic and mitigating its effects on citizens.

for CSCSD:

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